



DoView Tool G11 - Impact Evaluation Design Types

Make sure that all of the possible impact evaluation design types that could be used with an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative are considered. These design types can be remembered with the acronym IMPACTS (the relevant letter is included after each of the design types).

1 True experimental designs (T)

Randomly assign people / units to an intervention (treatment) and a control (no treatment) group. Compare the outcomes for the two groups. Because the only difference between the two groups is likely to be that the intervention group received the intervention, the intervention is likely to have caused any improvement in outcomes.

2 Time Series designs (S)

Needs many observations of high-level outcome indicators over time and for the intervention to start at a specific point in time. Look to see if there is a clear improvement in high-level outcome(s) at the point in time when intervention starts.

3 Constructed comparison group designs (C)

When you can not do random assignment, look around for naturally occurring situations where there is a group similar to the intervention group apart from it receiving the intervention (comparison group) not receiving the intervention; or construct a statistical comparison group (propensity analysis).

4 Alternative explanations elimination designs (A)

Where able to measure that high-level outcomes have occurred, identify all of the alternative explanations, then eliminate them all and therefore assume that the intervention caused the improvement in outcomes.

5 Expert Peer-review judgment designs (P)

Ask an expert(s) to make a judgment as to whether they think that the intervention had an impact using whatever methodology they, and other experts, normally use.

6 Key Informant judgment designs (I)

Ask a group of people who are likely to know what happened in the intervention to make a judgment as to whether they think that the intervention had an impact, because they are in a position to know.

7 Intervention logic model (theory-based) designs (M)

Get your intervention logic (e.g., a visual strategy diagram, theory of change, logic model) validated by previous research and evaluation evidence and/or expert review. Measure that the lower levels of the model are being implemented. Measure that the high-level outcomes are occurring and then assume that the intervention is causing the high-level outcomes to occur.

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